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WHAT IS pale gold in colour, smells of citrus fruits and honey with notes of vanilla and salted caramel, and tastes like heaven? Whisky, of course! And where do you go when you want to explore the best whisky in the world? Scotland, of course! And so it was that I landed in Aberdeen last month and drove to Keith, abode of whisky legends like Chivas Regal and The Glenlivet.

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Much like Nessie, kilts, and bagpipes, Scotland is inseparable from whisky, its national drink. Whisky has played an integral role in Scottish life since 1494. The term 'whisky' comes from the Gaelic 'uisge beatha' or 'usquebaugh', (don't even try pronouncing it!) which means 'water of life'. For whisky to be called Scotch, it must be made in Scotland. There are other rules too—it has to be made from just three natural ingredients (water, yeast and cereal), and it must be matured in oak casks for a minimum of three years.

So popular is Scotch across the globe that 53 bottles are shipped to over 180 countries around the world every second. Last year, Scotland exported whisky worth £6.2 billion, accounting for 26 per cent of all of Scotland's international goods exports.

There's another upside to the popularity of Scotch whisky worldwide—an increasingly large number of people are flocking to its distilleries to discover the process behind the spirit. In 2019, the Scotch Whisky



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Association reported a record 2.2 million visits to whisky distilleries, making it one of the most popular attractions in Scotland. Most distilleries across the country have visitor centres with in-house guides giving curious visitors tours of the operations.

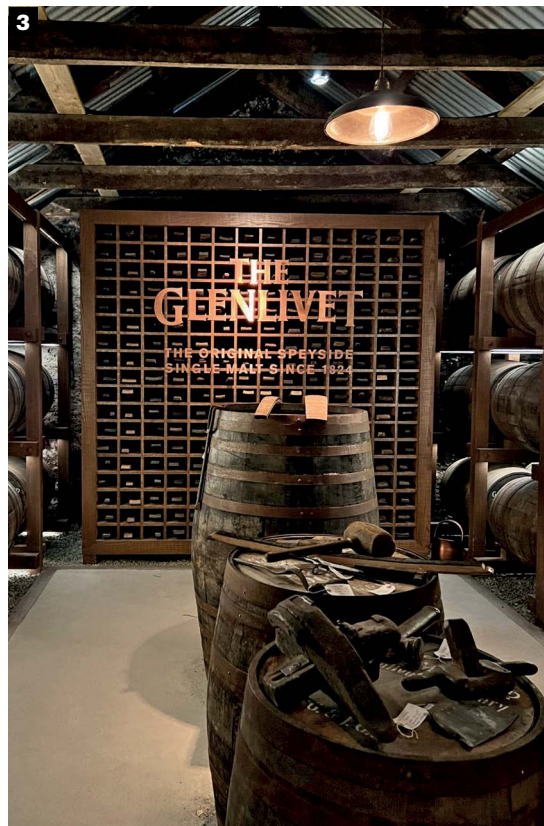
I joined one such tour to learn more about three legendary brands—Chivas Regal, Royal Salute and The Glenlivet. My first stop was Strathisla—the oldest continuously operating distillery in the Highlands and home of Chivas Regal, as the premium blended Scotch is primarily made up of whisky from this distillery. With its double pagodas, cobbled courtyard and enchanting grounds, Strathisla, established in 1786, seems more like something out of a fairytale than a distillery. It was in 1844 that James Chivas, founder of Chivas Brothers, who was at that time trading in herbs and spices, was granted a royal warrant by Queen Victoria making him an official supplier to the royal household. And that's where the word 'Regal' comes from in the Chivas Regal name, our guide tells us. Legend has it that no task was too small or too big for James Chivas and that Queen Victoria asked him to provide her with a grand piano, a case of whisky and a quiet donkey that she could walk

1 Strathisla, the oldest continuously operating distillery in the Highlands and home of Chivas Regal

2 Not much has changed in the whisky making process in over 200 years

3 The Glenlivet, the first legal malt distillery in Scotland

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